



STRETCHING INTO A SNOWY HORIZON, thousands of reindeer trek toward the Yamal Peninsula. It is early spring but the temperatures can drop to below -22°F (-30°C), and the winds are chilling. The Nenets and their reindeer are traveling the 600 miles (1,000 km) from their winter camp, farther south in the Boreal forest, to the summer pastures of the tundra. The journey takes about three months. They travel in a long and spectacular line stretching back miles along the landscape, which consists of 4,000–5,000 reindeer pulling endless rows of wooden sleds covered by thick, furry reindeer pelts. The reindeer walk naturally in lines when the snow is soft, following the prints of the animal in front; otherwise they walk in groups. The women and children in their hooded coats travel on sleds with every belonging they own. They are heading toward the lush, green grass of the tundra, where they can rest and the reindeer can fatten up for three months before embarking on the same three-month route back again in the fall.